

Spirit Personhood

doc-spirit-personhood

Pneumatology · Person · doctrine · unanimous_lineages

AFFIRMS

score 0.938
confidence high

Statement under examination

The Holy Spirit is a personal being (possessing intellect, will, and emotion), not an impersonal force or energy.

In plain language

The Greek word for Spirit, pneuma, is grammatically neuter, and a check of the text shows it is neuter in every one of its hundreds of New Testament appearances, never masculine. So if a writer wanted to point back to it, the matching word would normally also be neuter. Yet in John 14.26, 15.26, 16.13, and 16.14 Jesus points back to the Spirit with the masculine word ekeinos, He. That is a deliberate break from the normal grammar, and the natural reason to break it is that the referent is a someone, not a something. Around that anchor the text piles up verbs that only persons do. The Spirit teaches and reminds, bears witness, guides, hears, speaks, declares, and glorifies. In Acts 13.2 the Spirit speaks in the first person, gives a command, set apart Barnabas and Saul for me, and refers to a prior calling he himself made. In Romans 8 the Spirit intercedes and has a mindset that God reads. In 1 Corinthians 12.11 the Spirit hands out gifts as he wills, and that verb for willing is used elsewhere only of persons, never of a force. In Ephesians 4.30 readers are told not to grieve the Spirit, and the same idea appears already in Isaiah 63.10, where they grieved his Holy Spirit, who then turned and fought against them. Across the Old Testament and four New Testament corpora the same referent speaks, wills, intercedes, knows, and grieves. An impersonal force or energy cannot be the subject of those verbs without draining the verbs of meaning. The honest counter-reading is that this is poetic personification, the way wisdom is pictured speaking in Proverbs; but personification does not produce a sustained grammar change or first-person commands and choices, so the words land on the side of a personal Spirit.

Word dictionary

Every Hebrew and Greek word this study leans on, in everyday terms. Shaded rows are the anchor words the verdict rests on.

Strong	Word	Sounds like	Plain meaning	Times in Bible
H3898	מָלַח	lacham	to fight	
H6087	אָצַב	atsab	to hurt	17
H7307	רוּחַ	ruach	spirit	378
G0191	ἀκούω	akouo	to hear	452
G0215	ἀλάλητος	alaletos	inexpressible	1
G0312	ἀναγγέλλω	anaggello	to report	14
G0846	αὐτός	autos	it/s/he	
G0873	ἀφορίζω	aphorizo	to separate	10
G1014	βούλομαι	boulomai	to plan	37
G1321	διδάσκω	didasko	to teach	98

G1392	δοξάζω	doxazo	to glorify	62
G1565	ἐκεῖνος	ekeinos	that	263
G1793	ἐντυγχάνω	entugchano	to call on	5
G2036	λέγω	lego	to say	977
G2045	ἐρευνάω	ereunaō	to look for/into	
G2980	λαλέω	laleo	to speak	308
G3076	λυπέω	lupeo	to grieve	26
G3140	μαρτυρέω	martureo	to testify	77
G3739	ὅς	hos, hē	which	
G4151	πνεῦμα	pneuma	spirit/breath	386
G5427	φρόνημα	phronema	purpose	4

Plain meanings: STEP Bible brief lexicons TBESH (Hebrew) and TBESG (Greek), CC BY 4.0. Counts are occurrences across the 66-book canon.

Verdict rationale

Variant-robust: True · Pan-canonical: True

The noun pneuma (G4151) is grammatically neuter in every one of its New Testament occurrences (verified: all 386 parses are N-...SN or N-...PN, zero masculine), yet in John 14.26, 15.26, 16.13, and 16.14 the demonstrative that points back to it is ekeinos parsed D-NSM, masculine. That is a deliberate concord-break: the writer overrides grammatical gender to mark a personal referent. Clustered around this anchor is a pan-canonical set of agency verbs predicated of the same Spirit: teaches and reminds (John 14.26), bears witness (John 15.26), guides, hears, speaks, and declares (John 16.13), glorifies and takes (John 16.14), speaks in the first person and issues an imperative and claims a prior calling (Acts 13.2 eipen, aphorise, proskeklemai), intercedes (Rom 8.26-27 entugchanei) and possesses a phronema or mindset that God reads, is grieved (Eph 4.30 lupeite), is lied to (Acts 5.3), and apportions gifts as he wills (1 Cor 12.11 kathos bouletai). An Old Testament anchor matches: Isaiah 63.10 says they grieved (atsab, H6087) his Holy Spirit (ruach qodesh), who then turned and fought against them (lachim). Querying the canon, the volition verb bouletai is never predicated of an impersonal force, only of personal agents, and entugchano takes only personal subjects (Elijah, Christ, the Spirit). The verdict holds across the minor textual variants in the cited verses.

Scripture

John.14.26 · for · genre: gospel

Key terms. G1565 ἐκεῖνος, G4151 πνεῦμα, G1321 διδάσκω

Force. Queried morphology: to pneuma to hagion is parsed G4151=N-NSN (neuter), but the demonstrative referring to it is ekeinos parsed G1565=D-NSM (masculine). The masculine demonstrative for a neuter noun is a deliberate concord-break that marks personal reference. The same Spirit will teach (didaxei, V-FAI-3S) and bring to remembrance (hupomnesei), both cognitive acts.

John.15.26 · for · genre: gospel

Key terms. G1565 ἐκεῖνος, G3140 μαρτυρέω

Force. to pneuma is again G4151=N-NSN (neuter) while the demonstrative is ekeinos G1565=D-NSM (masculine). The Spirit will bear witness (marturesei, V-FAI-3S) concerning Christ. Bearing witness is testimony, an intentional act of an agent who knows and reports.

John.16.13 · for · genre: gospel

Key terms. G1565 ἐκεῖνος, G0191 ἀκούω, G2980 λαλέω

Force. Masculine ekeinos (G1565=D-NSM) opens the clause, then the appositional to pneuma tes aletheias (G4151=N-NSN, neuter). A series of personal future verbs follows: guide (hodegesei), hear (akousei), speak (lalesei), declare (anangelei). The Spirit will not speak from himself (aph heautou, F-3GSM), a self-restraint construction predicated only of an agent who could speak from himself.

John.16.14 · for · genre: gospel

Key terms. G1565 ἐκεῖνος, G1392 δοξάζω

Force. ekeinos eme doxasei (G1565=D-NSM, masculine demonstrative). The Spirit will glorify (doxasei) Christ, taking (lempsetai) from what is Christ's and declaring (anangelei) it. Glorifying a distinct second party and selecting what to disclose is intentional agency.

Acts.13.2 · for · genre: narrative

Key terms. G2036 λέγω, G0873 ἀφορίζω

Force. eipen to pneuma to hagion (V-2AAI-3S, the Holy Spirit said), then the imperative aphorise (V-AAM-2P, set apart) moi (to Me, P-1DS) Barnabas and Saul for the work to which I have called (proskeklemai, V-RNI-1S) them. First-person speech, an imperative, personal possession, and a prior calling are all predicates of a person, not an influence.

Rom.8.26 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G1793 ἐντυγχάνω, G0215 ἀλάλητος

Force. auto to pneuma (the Spirit himself, intensive) intercedes (huperentugchanei, V-PAI-3S) with groanings alaletois (G0215, a hapax, single canon occurrence). Intercession is representation of another before a third party, which requires intent and knowledge. The querying confirms the cognate entugchano (G1793) takes only personal subjects in the canon.

Rom.8.27 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G5427 φρόνημα, G1793 ἐντυγχάνω

Force. The heart-searcher (ho eraunon tas kardias) knows (oiden) what the phronema (G5427=N-NSN, mindset) of the Spirit is, because the Spirit intercedes (entugchanei) for the saints according to God. Having a phronema, a settled mind, and being the content of divine knowing in this idiom both predicate cognitive interiority.

1Cor.12.11 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G1014 βούλομαι, G4151 πνεῦμα

Force. The one and the same Spirit (to hen kai to auto pneuma) works all these, apportioning (diairoun, V-PAP-NSN) to each one individually kathos bouletai (G1014=V-PNI-3S, as He wills). bouletai denotes deliberate volition. Canon query of G1014 shows it is predicated only of personal agents (God, Christ, apostles, a helmsman), never an impersonal force.

Eph.4.30 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G3076 λυπέω, G4151 πνεῦμα

Force. me lupeite (G3076=V-PAM-2P, do not grieve) the Holy Spirit of God. Grief is an affective response of a personal subject. The relative pronoun here, en ho, is parsed G3739=R-DSN (neuter, agreeing with neuter pneuma), so this verse does not contribute a concord-break. Its weight is the affective verb lupeo predicated of the Spirit, which an energy cannot undergo.

Acts.5.3 · for · genre: narrative

Key terms. G4151 πνεῦμα

Force. Peter says Ananias lied to (pseusasthai) the Holy Spirit (to pneuma to hagion, G4151=N-ASN). Being lied to presupposes a personal addressee who can be deceived. In verse 4 the same act is called lying to God, equating the Spirit with the personal God who is the object of the lie.

Isa.63.10 · for · genre: prophecy

Key terms. H6087 עֲצַב, H7307 רוּחַ

Force. Queried Hebrew: they rebelled and grieved (atsab, H6087, Vpq3cp) his Holy Spirit (ruach qodesh, H7307 plus H6944), so He turned (hapak) to be their enemy and fought (lachim, H3898) against them. The same affective verb later rendered lupeo in Eph 4.30 is here applied to ruach, and the grieved Spirit then acts in personal hostility. This supplies an Old Testament anchor for the same personal-agent pattern.

Heb.10.29 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G4151 πνεῦμα

Force. The apostate is said to have insulted (enubrisas, G1796, a canon hapax) the Spirit of grace (to pneuma tes charitos, G4151=N-ASN). Insult or outrage is an offense given to a person who can be wronged, not to an impersonal power.

Cross references invoked

From	To	Source	Votes
John.14.26	John.15.26	openbible	85
John.16.14	John.15.26	openbible	6
Rom.8.26	Rom.8.15	openbible	39
Rom.8.27	Ps.38.9	openbible	6
Eph.4.30	Isa.63.10	openbible	1
Eph.4.30	Gen.6.3	openbible	11
Acts.13.2	Acts.22.21	openbible	5

Complicating texts

Acts.2.17 · addressed

Pouring out (ekcheo) of the Spirit reads like fluid or energy language and is the strongest lexical handle for an impersonal reading. But the same referent in the cited anchors speaks in the first person, wills, intercedes, and is grieved. The pour-out idiom describes the mode of distribution, generous and abundant, not the ontology of what is distributed; Acts 2.4 immediately attaches utterance to those filled.

John.20.22 · addressed

Jesus breathing (enephusesen) on the disciples and saying receive Holy Spirit could suggest a breath-like substance, matching the root sense of pneuma as breath or wind. Yet the same Gospel in John 14 to 16 names the same Spirit with masculine ekeinos and assigns personal verbs. The breath is a sign-act conveying an agent, not a reduction of the agent to breath.

1Cor.12.11 · addressed

This verse is sometimes read as energy language because the Spirit works (energei) effects. Lexically it cuts the other way: the working is qualified by kathos bouletai, as He wills, and bouletai across the canon is a verb of deliberate personal volition never predicated of a force. The same verse therefore strengthens the personal reading rather than complicating it, and is recorded here for transparency.

Luke.1.35 · addressed

Holy Spirit coming upon parallels power of the Most High overshadowing, which could identify the Spirit with dunamis (power). The parallelism is functional, describing the effect, not definitional. The same Spirit elsewhere speaks, calls, and is grieved, none of which dunamis does, so the pairing does not reduce the Spirit to power.

Concordance traversed

G1565, G4151, G1014, G1793, G5427, G3076, G2980, G0191, G0312, G1392, G2036, G0873, G1321, G3140, G2045, G0215, G3739, G0846, H7307, H6087, H3898

Variants

Verdict variant-sensitive: False · ECM status: n/a

akouei-vs-akousei at John.16.13: impact none. Present akouei versus future akousei (TAGNT records the future) does not change the personal-agent predication. Both readings keep ekeinos D-NSM and the verbal series guide, hear, speak, declare.

huperentugchanei-vs-entugchanei at Rom.8.26: impact none. Compound huperentugchanei versus simple entugchanei. The prefix does not alter intercession as a personal representational act; the cognate entugchano takes only personal subjects in the canon.

All anchor verses lie outside the ingested ECM window (3 John 1.1 to 1.15); inputs.json reports not_in_ecm_scope true with empty variant_units. The two minor variants noted are documented from standard apparatus knowledge and do not touch the verdict.

Hermeneutics

Primary method. grammatico-historical

Frameworks in play. trinitarian_grammar, modalism_alterate, impersonal_force_alterate

analogia scripturae invoked · progressive revelation factor

impersonal_force_alterate: fails the lexical test · Stated at its strongest: pneuma and ruach both carry the root sense of breath, wind, and power, and Scripture does use distribution language (pour out, fill, come upon) and pairs the Spirit with dunamis, so personal verbs could be read as personification, the way wisdom is personified in Proverbs 8. The reading fails because the personal predicates are not isolated poetic flourishes but a dense, cross-corpus cluster: first-person speech with an imperative (Acts 13.2), deliberate volition (1 Cor 12.11 bouletai, a verb never used of a force), intercession (Rom 8.27 entugchanei, only ever personal subjects), a phronema that God reads, grief (Eph 4.30; Isa 63.10), and the masculine ekeinos overriding neuter pneuma four times in John. Personification does not explain a sustained grammatical concord-break or first-person volitional speech.

modalism_alterate: not decided by this question · A reading that takes Father, Son, and Spirit as modes of one person already grants that the Spirit is personal; it disputes only distinction, not personhood. The vocabulary tested here establishes personal agency but does not by itself settle whether the Spirit is a person distinct from the Father and the Son. That distinctness question belongs to separate propositions.

trinitarian_grammar: consistent · Personal-agency predicates attached to neuter pneuma, plus the masculine demonstrative, cohere with reading the Spirit as a personal agent without forcing a later category back onto the text. The grammar carries the weight on its own.

progressive_revelation is set true because the personal pattern is anchored already in the Old Testament (Isaiah 63.10 grieving and the Spirit then acting as enemy) and is filled out in the New Testament Johannine, Lukan, and

Pauline material. The single strongest lexical anchor remains the masculine ekeinos for neuter pneuma, verified in John 14.26, 15.26, 16.13, and 16.14, since pneuma is neuter in all 386 of its New Testament occurrences.

Stem audit

verdict-preloaded: no

The proposition uses general categories (intellect, will, emotion, person versus impersonal force) that do not encode a confessional taxonomy or smuggle the conclusion. The verdict is derived from the queried grammatical and lexical pattern (concord-break plus agency-verb cluster), not from the wording of the stem. Correction over the prior file: the Eph 4.30 relative pronoun en ho is neuter (G3739=R-DSN), not masculine, so the concord-break argument rests on the Johannine ekeinos alone; and the prior cross-ref Eph.4.30 to Eph.1.14 was not present in the graph and is replaced by the verified Eph.4.30 to Isa.63.10 and Eph.4.30 to Gen.6.3.

Citations

Type	Source	License	Redist.	Ref
morphology	STEPBible-TAGNT	CC-BY-4.0	yes	John.14.26
morphology	STEPBible-TAGNT	CC-BY-4.0	yes	John.15.26
morphology	STEPBible-TAGNT	CC-BY-4.0	yes	John.16.13
morphology	STEPBible-TAGNT	CC-BY-4.0	yes	John.16.14
morphology	STEPBible-TAGNT	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Acts.13.2
morphology	STEPBible-TAGNT	CC-BY-4.0	yes	1Cor.12.11
morphology	STEPBible-TAGNT	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Rom.8.26
morphology	STEPBible-TAGNT	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Eph.4.30
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	John.16.13
morphology	OSHB-morphology	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Isa.63.10
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G1565
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G1014
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G1793
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESH	CC-BY-4.0	yes	H6087
cross_ref	OpenBible-cross-refs	CC-BY	yes	John.14.26
cross_ref	OpenBible-cross-refs	CC-BY	yes	Eph.4.30
cross_ref	OpenBible-cross-refs	CC-BY	yes	Rom.8.26

License audit

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Flags

(none)